LEISURE

An Equal Music

OTT

A new OTT series—*Equals* on JioCinema—puts the spotlight on folk artists from across India

"If we want someone to gulp down something bitter—by bitter, I mean classical [music]—the platter should be presented well. Then they will eat it, bitter or sweet," says Varanasi-based thumri singer Sucharita Gupta about her song with Hindi pop-rock band The Yellow Diary, in the opening episode of *Equals*, a new seven-part music documentary series on JioCinema.

Conceptualised by New Delhi-based non-profit Anahad Foundation, which works to catalogue and release the work of folk musicians and enhance their revenue-generating opportunities, *Equals* spotlights seven of the country's most prominent folk artists by tracing their stories and getting them to create a song with their more mainstream counterparts. In other words, as Gupta says, it offers their music in a more appealing package.

The combinations include Punjabi vocalist Des Raj Lachkani from Patiala with pop-rock duo Faridkot; Rajasthani singer Jumma Jogi from Alwar with folk-fusion rock band Swarathma; Baul musician Rina Das from Santiniketan with Hindi post-rock group Aswekeepsearching; Assamese singer Dulal Manki from Tinsukia with Hindustani classical-fusion pop duo Shadow and Light; Kabir bhajan singer Prahlad Tipaniya from Ujjain with genre-crossing singer and flute player Rasika Shekar; and Qawwali duo Warsi Brothers from Hyderabad with composer Ricky Kej.

Equals gets seven of India's most prominent folk artists to create a song with their more mainstream counterparts

The documentary takes its cue from Equals Sessions, a self-funded YouTube music video series put together by Anahad in 2019, the key difference being that the earlier series paired younger, lesser-known folk musicians who were primarily performers with popular independent music bands to help them learn the art of composing. For example, Punjabi singer Amar Jalal and his group wrote 'Nasha' with Faridkot, which became such a hit that they went on to recreate it for the 2022 Hindi film *An Action Hero*.

In the 2019 Equals Sessions, the indie acts served as mentors.

MUSIC

Chord Progression

Two veteran Indian rock acts—**Uday Benegal** and **Parikrama**—have returned with new singles

Fans of Indus Creed frontman and vocalist Uday Benegal can thank British singer/songwriter and podcaster Jack Stafford for the former's debut solo single 'Hollow Bones'. The 1960s-recalling ballad was composed after Stafford invited Benegal to be a guest on his podcast Podsongs. On the show, musicians interview non-musicians whose work they admire and respect, following which Stafford and the artist write and record a song together.

Benegal chose to interview Manjiri Latey whose telepathic animal communication course he completed after wanting to understand the anxieties of the family of dogs he feeds and looks out for, near his building in Goa. "The course was incredibly fascinating," says Benegal. "I realised it's the starting gate of a much wider and deeper exploration into one's own connectedness to all things and beings." Though Benegal got Indus Creed members, guitarist Mahesh Tinaikar and keyboardist Zubin Balaporia, to play on 'Hollow Bones', it



Uday Benegal

SIDDHARTH SAMANT



Members of Parikrama